

Integrating Ourselves

*Building bridges and coalitions
to create wholeness*

By Deborah L. Johnson

I have been asked to share with you a few of my personal perceptions regarding the National Black Gay and Lesbian Leadership Forum and the Conference which it sponsors. I'm here to talk about its purpose and its significance. But first I'd like to share with you something that happened to me personally.

Although this particular incident happened several years ago, it so typifies the experience that I encounter while doing education and outreach as a black lesbian. I was making a presentation to a group of freshmen on UCLA's campus. There were about 60 to 70 students there, all black, as part of an EEOP program. I was the only black person on a panel of seven people. Of course, the one thing that everyone wanted to know was why was I on this panel with all these gay people because, after all, I was black and had no business being there. They were obviously deeply disturbed by my presence.

At one point, a very angry young man with an extremely

hostile attitude towards me rushes up to me and demands that I tell the audience whether I experience more oppression as a black person or as a gay person. I looked him dead in the eye and explained, "If you have your foot on my neck, I don't really care why it's there. Whether it's there because I am black, or because I'm a woman, or because I'm gay, it doesn't hurt any less. Just get your foot off."

A couple of weeks ago, I was teaching a relationship workshop series. One of the sessions was entitled "Maintaining Your Integrity." In preparation for the workshop, I went to Webster's Dictionary and I looked up the word "integrity." I found that "integrity" came from the Latin root word "integer" which means to make "whole." Integrity is a noun. The verb form of the word "integer" is "integrate." I thought to myself, "Isn't that interesting?" An integration is a coming together of various parts, not for the sake of the coming together, but to make a whole.

I believe that the National Black Gay and Lesbian Leadership Forum and its Conferences allow us to integrate our lives as individuals. The Forum and Conferences allow us to be all that we are simultaneously and harmoniously. Integrity implies maintaining a consistency of your wholeness. To have integrity means to take all of you with you wherever you go, not leaving parts of you behind. It means not abandoning, not denying parts of you because they appear to be inappropriate for the environment that you are in. Integrity means being all that you are whenever and wherever you are.

The Forum and the Conferences allow us to be both black and lesbian or gay, *at the same time without having to choose between the two* in our activism. For so long the gay and lesbian community has not been able to incorporate us because it hasn't known how to deal with our blackness. The black community, on the other hand, couldn't handle our gayness. After all, you know that's the social disease we picked up from the Anglo Society which then makes our "blackness" a little questionable. So we've been too black for one community and not black enough for the other. Just what is a person to do?

Most of us in this room have been the proverbial "them" that everyone is always talking about—the ones on the fringes, the periphery, the outskirts of life that no one ever deals with until there is some kind of uprising. But, through organizations like the National Black Gay and Lesbian Leadership Forum, we are making a place for ourselves in the center core of things. We are becoming an integral part of society. I am a professional consultant to numerous organization. In my work I can see that both the black and the gay and lesbian communities are beginning to redefine themselves. It's an evolutionary process. It's slow, but it is happening. These communities are moving away from the "us" versus "them" mentality into a new definition of who the "we" is. Thank God that the expanding definition has begun to include most of us in this room. And rightfully so,



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for we have made significant contributions, as well. We've done our share.

Arriving at this point of an integrated wholeness is an important step in creating stability both in one's personal life and politically. When you are at cross purposes with yourself you are fragmented. A house divided against itself cannot long stand. When we are divided, we are too easily conquered. Part of what we are able to do at this Conference is experience our strength in numbers.

What we have in this Conference is a forum in which we can exchange information, form alliances, define ourselves, explore our issues and concerns. We are shedding our invisibility and our isolationism which, in of itself, is making us more powerful. We have here an opportunity to train and educate ourselves, to embrace our history and our culture, and to determine where we are headed in our future.

The National Black Gay and Lesbian Forum and its Conferences also provides a tangible focal point enabling others to reach us and learn more about us. For too long, the burden of cultural pluralism and sexual diversity has been on our backs to go out and explain to others who we are and what we are about. The Forum and its Conferences provides an opportunity for other to come and see for themselves.

Through this Conference, we are building bridges and coalitions. We are not trying to get power from somewhere else. We are exercising our own. We are not asking for a seat at the table of another. We are preparing our own meal and sharing it with all of those who would partake. We now have a collective voice that is being heard by politicians, educators, civic leaders, entertainers, the clergy, and the medical community. Just last night we partied hard as Catch One. But we didn't only party. We raised money to educate our community about the dreaded disease AIDS and ways to prevent its spread.

Less than a year ago, at that same black gay establishment, we held hands in prayer for our PWAs with Jesse

Jackson. A Presidential candidate came to see us on our turf and it was the National Black Gay and Lesbian Leadership Forum that got him there.

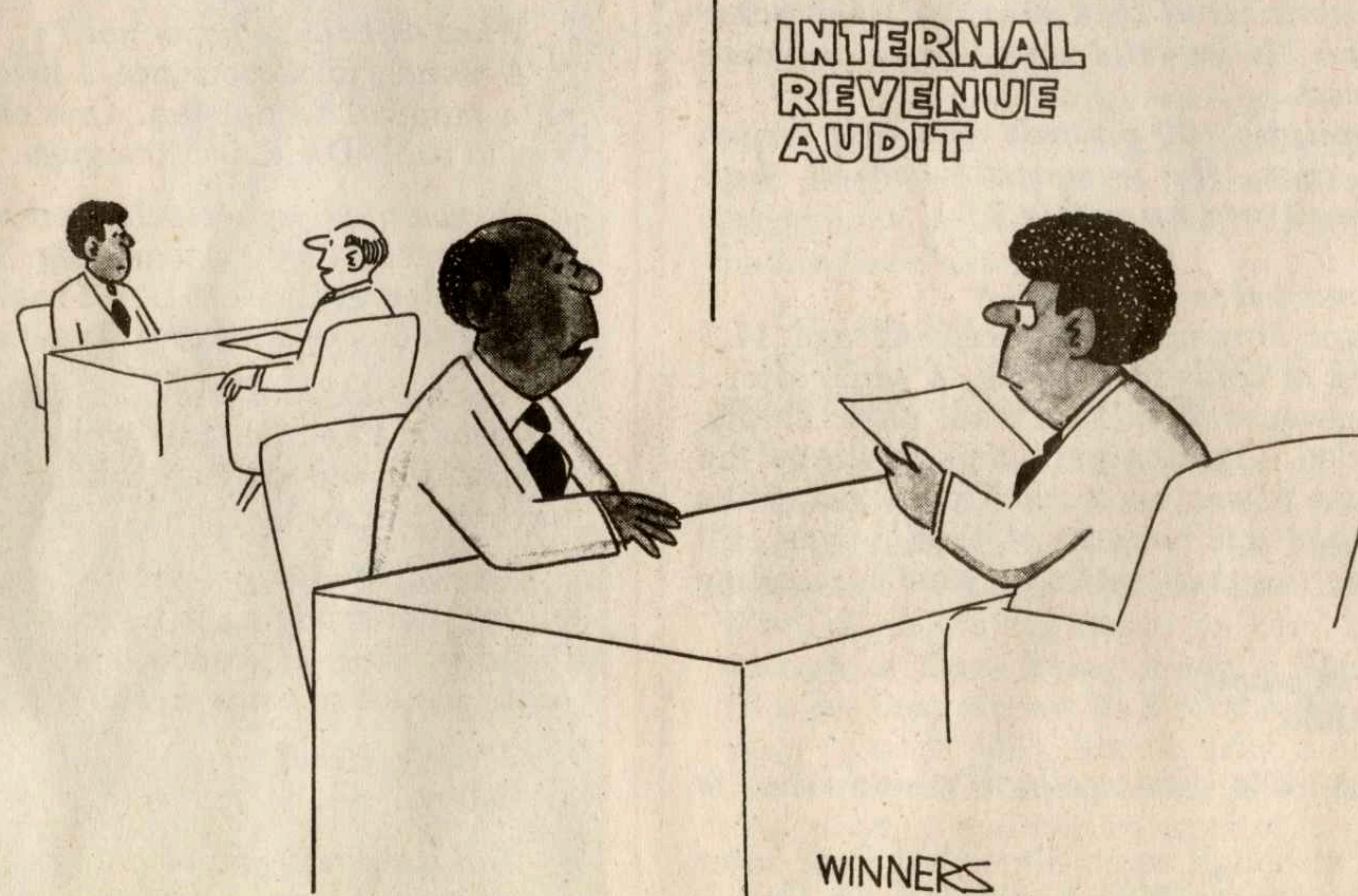
Mark my words, something important is happening here and by your presence tonight you are all a part of it. We are at the dawning of a new era in our history. It's exciting. It's empowering. It's inevitable. And it's now! By our proclamation that we are who we are, all of what we are, wherever we are, we bring a new level of integrity to our own lives and to all the social/political movements that we have always been a part of.

When, I look at the Forum and its Conferences, I see education, leadership development, and AIDS awareness. I see networking, coalition building, and the formulation of political strategies. But I also see having fun, caring, sharing. Perhaps most importantly of all, I see healing, much needed healing. To me this spells pride, hope for the future, and a better life for us all.

I am not one to be easily impressed. But I have been deeply impressed with what the National Black Gay and Lesbian Forum has been able to accomplish in a relatively brief period of time. Everyone who has been involved with making this so deserves to be commended. I'm asking you tonight to aide the Forum in giving us a voice, in giving us vehicles like this Conference through which we can interact with each other. Within the next few days, you will be given several opportunities to contribute to the Forum your money, your time, your talent, and your love. Take them. Not only does the Forum need your support, I think it deserves it, as well.

As I look around this room tonight I can only say that I'm very glad that we are all here, that we have it to this point. And from my perspective, it's about time! Thank you and good evening.

The foregoing is the complete text of Deborah L. Johnson's keynote address presented February 18, 1989 at the National Black Gay and Lesbian Leadership Conference Banquet.



"Well, then, suppose we don't deduct for the lube and condoms."